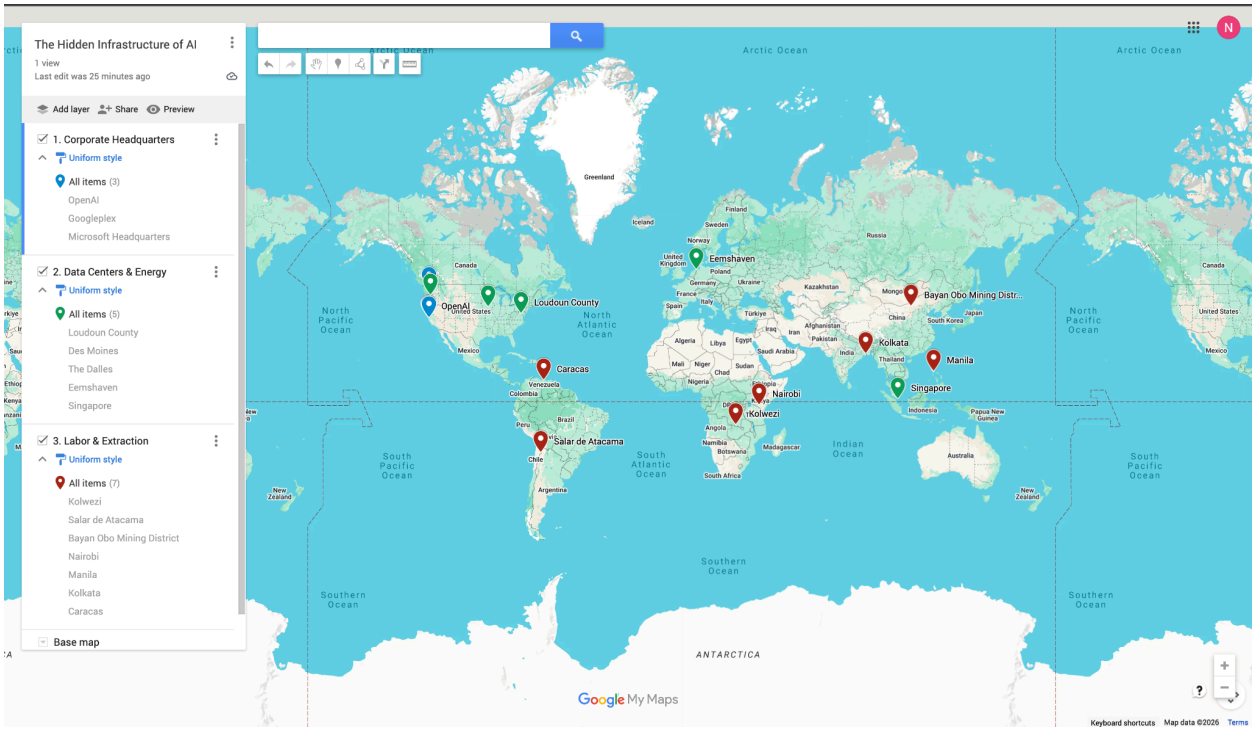
# Make 06: The Hidden Infrastructure of AI

**Digital Map Link:**
https://www.google.com/maps/d/u/0/edit?mid=1LM3KV9Oc70RZp_HCa2_4Qgg9WaFMG24&usp=sharing




## 1. Map Overview & Layer Structure

This project maps the physical, environmental, and labor networks that power artificial intelligence, counteracting the common myth that AI exists in an abstract, immaterial "cloud."

- **Layer 1: Corporate Headquarters (Blue)** — Sites of executive power, capital accumulation, and strategic decision-making (OpenAI, Googleplex, Microsoft).
- **Layer 2: Data Centers & Energy (Green)** — High-energy infrastructure nodes and cooling facilities consuming massive amounts of land, power, and local water resources (Loudoun County, Des Moines, The Dalles, Eemshaven, Singapore).
- **Layer 3: Labor & Extraction (Red)** — The supply chains of raw material extraction and outsourced, low-wage human labor that build, train, and moderate AI systems (Cobalt in DRC, Lithium in Chile, Rare Earths in China, Data Moderation/Labeling in Kenya, Philippines, India, and Venezuela).

# 2. Research Documentation

**Primary Sources Used:**

To map these hidden geographies, I relied on Kate Crawford's *Atlas of AI*, research publications from the *AI Now Institute*, environmental impact reports from Greenpeace, and investigative journalism from outlets such as *TIME Magazine*, *Rest of World*, and *The Guardian*.

**What Was Hardest to Find?**

The most difficult layer to uncover was the precise geographic location of outsourced data labeling and content moderation hubs. While major tech companies eagerly publicize their Silicon Valley headquarters and celebrate investments in new data centers, offices housing third-party contract workers, such as Sama in Nairobi or TaskUs in Manila, are intentionally obscured under strict non-disclosure agreements (NDAs) and corporate subcontracting layers. This difficulty reveals a fundamental truth: tech corporations actively work to hide the precarious human labor necessary to make AI systems appear "automated" and "safe."

**Key Surprises:**

The most striking finding was the immediate, localized ecological strain caused by data center cooling. Discovering that servers running large language models in Des Moines, Iowa, consume millions of gallons of local drinking water during severe droughts, competing directly with surrounding agricultural communities, demonstrates the tangible footprint of LLM training. The visual contrast between Silicon Valley's hyper-concentration of capital and the sacrifice zones in the Global South proves that AI is an extractive planetary assembly line.

# 3. Artist Statement

This map argues that the AI "cloud" is an extractive, deeply unequal physical infrastructure rooted in environmental exploitation and outsourced neocolonial labor. By juxtaposing Silicon Valley executive hubs against mineral extraction sites and low-wage data moderation hubs in the Global South, the map dismantles the narrative of AI as a clean, immaterial, and objective technology.

Connecting directly to Data Feminism (D'Ignazio & Klein), this project uses counter-mapping to challenge institutional power asymmetries and expose the invisible labor that powers digital systems. Rather than treating map data as neutral representation, the visual design intentionally highlights who benefits financially and decisionally from AI versus who bears the ecological and psychological burdens of its production.

If drawn by a tech CEO, this map would emphasize fiber-optic network speeds, server efficiencies, and market valuations while completely erasing mining conditions and trauma-exposed content moderators. Conversely, if drawn by a content moderator in Nairobi or

a farmer in Iowa, the center of gravity would shift away from California toward zones of human and ecological sacrifice. The deliberate omission of corporate performance metrics in this map serves to prioritize precisely what the tech industry tries to render invisible.

# 4. Attribution & Sources

- **Mapping Platform:** Google My Maps
- **AI Assistance Disclosure:** Generative AI (Gemini) was used strictly as a research assistant to identify relevant geographic locations and verify which corporations operate at each site.
- **References:**


Crawford, Kate. *Atlas of AI: Power, Politics, and the Planetary Costs of Artificial Intelligence*. Yale University Press, 2021.

D'Ignazio, Catherine, and Lauren Klein. *Data Feminism*. MIT Press, 2020.

Perrigo, Billy. "OpenAI Used Kenyan Workers Making Less Than $2 Per Hour to Make ChatGPT Less Toxic." *TIME Magazine*, 2023.